

Chapter 29: When It Stops Feeling Like a Game

Jenny noticed the shift first in how she stopped correcting him.

Not out loud.

Not in her head either.

Austin said things now—small, decisive things—and she no longer immediately pushed back.

It didn't mean she agreed.

It meant she was getting used to it.

And that scared her more than she wanted to admit.

He was already there when she arrived.

Again.

Jenny paused at the entrance.

"...You're early," she said automatically.

Austin looked up.

"I came earlier on purpose."

That made her frown.

"Why?"

A pause.

Then—

"I wanted to see you before you got busy."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You say that like it's normal."

"It is becoming normal."

She narrowed her eyes.

"That's the problem."

Austin didn't react defensively.

He rarely did now.

Instead, he simply said,

"I disagree."

That made her stop for half a second.

"...Of course you do."

He watched her quietly.

Jenny exhaled.

"You're too calm about all of this."

"I'm not calm," he corrected.

"You look calm."

"I've learned how to stay still."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"That sounds worse."

"It's not," he said. "It's just control."

That word again.

Control.

Jenny looked away.

Of course she did.

Later, when the restaurant filled, Jenny moved on instinct.

Orders.

Tables.

Noise.

But Austin stayed in her awareness even when she wasn't looking at him.

That was the new problem.

He wasn't just present.

He was *mapped* into her attention.

She hated that.

Bao leaned toward her during a break.

"You're less tense around him now."

"I'm not."

"You are."

"I'm just used to him."

Bao raised an eyebrow.

"That's worse."

Jenny didn't respond.

Because it was.

When things slowed, Jenny finally approached him.

"You didn't order much today," she said.

"I wasn't hungry."

"Then why are you here?"

Austin looked up.

"I like being here."

Jenny sighed.

"You keep saying that like it explains everything."

"It explains enough."

A pause.

Then she asked quietly,

"Enough for what?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"For me to stay."

That word again.

Stay.

Jenny frowned.

"You're making staying sound like a decision instead of a habit."

"It is a decision," he said.

Jenny tilted her head.

"You say that so easily."

"It wasn't easy to arrive at."

That made her pause.

Austin leaned slightly forward.

"I used to think relationships were something that happened to me," he said.

Jenny listened.

"Now?"

"Now I think they're something I choose to remain in."

That hit differently.

Not romantic.

Not exaggerated.

Just... structured.

Jenny didn't know how to respond to that.

So she defaulted to caution.

"And you think this is a relationship?"

A pause.

Then calmly—

"I think it's becoming one."

Jenny exhaled sharply.

"That's not something you decide alone."

"I'm not deciding it alone," he said.

"I'm telling you where I stand."

That made her go still.

Because he wasn't forcing anything.

He was placing himself in the open.

And leaving it there.

By closing time, the air felt heavier than usual.

Not tense.

Just full.

Jenny walked over to him slowly.

"You're still here," she said softly.

"Yes."

She hesitated.

Then asked,

"Do you ever get tired of waiting for me to respond to all this?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then—

"I'm not waiting for your response anymore."

Jenny frowned.

"...What does that mean?"

"It means I'm not here temporarily until you decide something."

A pause.

"I'm here regardless."

That made her chest tighten slightly.

"That sounds dangerous," she said quietly.

"To you?"

"To everything."

Austin nodded once.

"Maybe."

Then he added softer,

"But I think I'm past the point of reversing it."

Silence.

Jenny felt it again.

That shift.

Not loud.

Not dramatic.

Just irreversible in shape.

She looked away.

Of course she did.

But this time...

She didn't tell him to leave.

She didn't question his presence.

She just said quietly,

"I need to finish closing."

Austin stood.

"I'll walk you."

Jenny nodded.

"...Okay."

And this time, when she said it...

It didn't feel like acceptance of a situation.

It felt like acceptance of a person standing inside it.